

Tone - Study Guide

Identify an author or speaker's attitude and prove it with exact wording from the text.

Learning goal

Infer tone from several textual cues and select the words or phrases that best support that tone judgment.

What this skill really means

Tone is the attitude conveyed by the writer or speaker toward a subject, person, audience, or situation. It is built through word choice, details, sentence structure, and sometimes what the writer chooses to emphasize.

Tone is not the same as topic, mood, or your own reaction. A passage about a serious problem can have a hopeful, frustrated, cautious, humorous, or neutral tone.

Concept	Question it answers	Example
Topic	What is the passage about?	a delayed train project
Tone	How does the writer seem to feel about it?	skeptical
Mood	What feeling does the passage create in the reader?	uneasy
Purpose	Why did the writer write this?	to argue for stricter oversight

How exam-style questions ask it

- Which word best describes the author's tone toward ___?

- Which phrase most clearly contributes to the ____ tone?
- How does the tone change between paragraphs 2 and 4?

A reliable method

1. Name the subject of the attitude. Tone toward what?
2. Collect at least two cues - especially evaluative adjectives, verbs, comparisons, or repeated emphasis.
3. Choose a precise tone word that fits all the cues.
4. Reject extreme tone words unless the language is equally extreme.
5. For evidence questions, choose wording that carries attitude, not a neutral factual detail.

Tips and shortcuts

- Use a tone ladder: positive/negative/neutral first, then choose a precise word such as appreciative, cautious, skeptical, frustrated, admiring, or urgent.
- If one word sounds emotional but the rest is neutral, do not let that one word control the answer.
- Tone can shift. Recheck the paragraph named in the question.

Worked examples

Example 1

The committee called the proposal "ambitious," but noted that its cost estimates were "still incomplete" and that several deadlines were "optimistic at best."

1. Which word best describes the committee's tone?

- A. celebratory
- B. cautious
- C. furious
- D. amused

Answer: B

The committee acknowledges ambition but repeatedly qualifies its support. The tone is cautious rather than openly hostile.

Example 2

"At last, the neighborhood has a playground designed with children instead of merely for them," the organizer said.

2. Which phrase most strongly creates an approving tone?

- A. the neighborhood
- B. has a playground
- C. At last
- D. the organizer said

Answer: C

At last signals relief and approval that a long-awaited improvement has finally happened.

Common traps

- Choosing the topic instead of an attitude.
- Choosing an extreme word such as furious when the passage is only critical.

- Using your own reaction instead of the author's wording.
- Selecting a factual sentence as evidence when it contains no attitude.

Self-check rule

Before accepting an answer, point to the exact word, phrase, or surrounding detail that proves your interpretation. If you cannot point to evidence, recheck the choice.

Quick check

1. What tone is suggested by "a promising start, though several questions remain"?
2. Which is more precise for mild doubt: skeptical or furious?
3. Why should tone evidence usually contain evaluative wording?

Quick check guidance

Say your answer in plain language and explain which exact wording in the sentence or passage supports it. The goal is evidence-based interpretation, not memorizing labels.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You identify the topic instead of the author's attitude.

Try: Finish this sentence: The author sounds ___ about ___. The blank needs an attitude word.

2

If: You choose an extreme tone label for mild wording.

Try: Match intensity. A cautious passage is not automatically fearful; criticism is not automatically anger.

3

If: You use your own reaction as evidence.

Try: Point to evaluative words, comparisons, or details chosen by the author. Tone comes from the text, not your feelings.

30-second reset

Before the next tone question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.